10 AIRLINES. UK + INDIA. MAR TO AUG 2026 VS 2025.

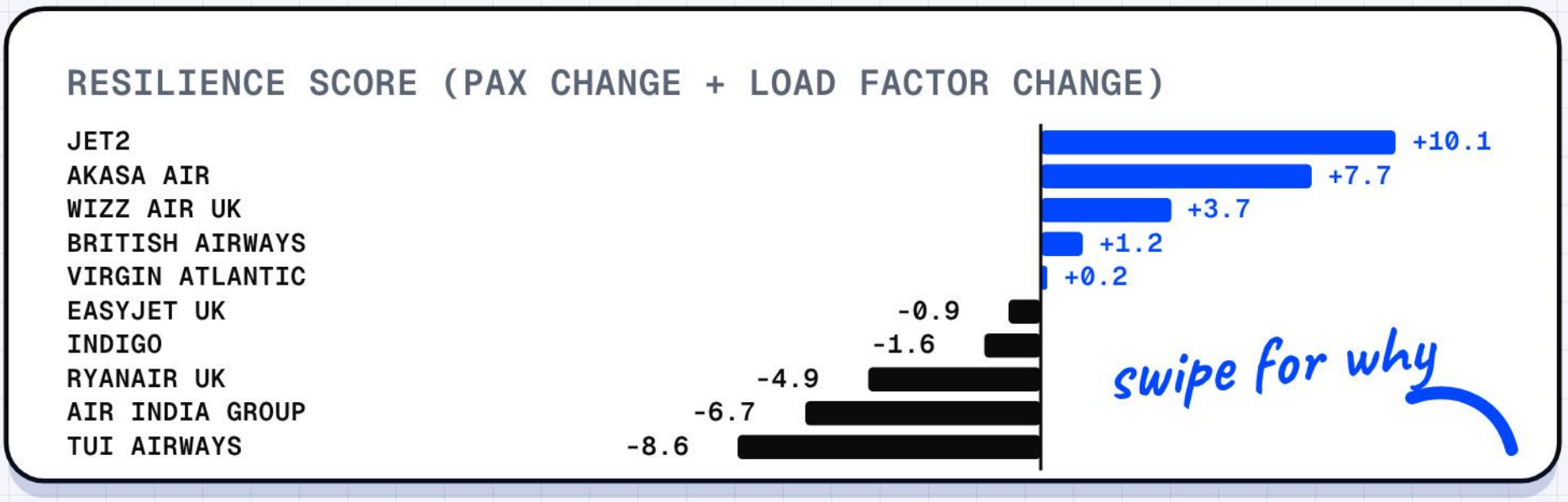
Cut seats or add seats?

Jet2 +8.9% pax

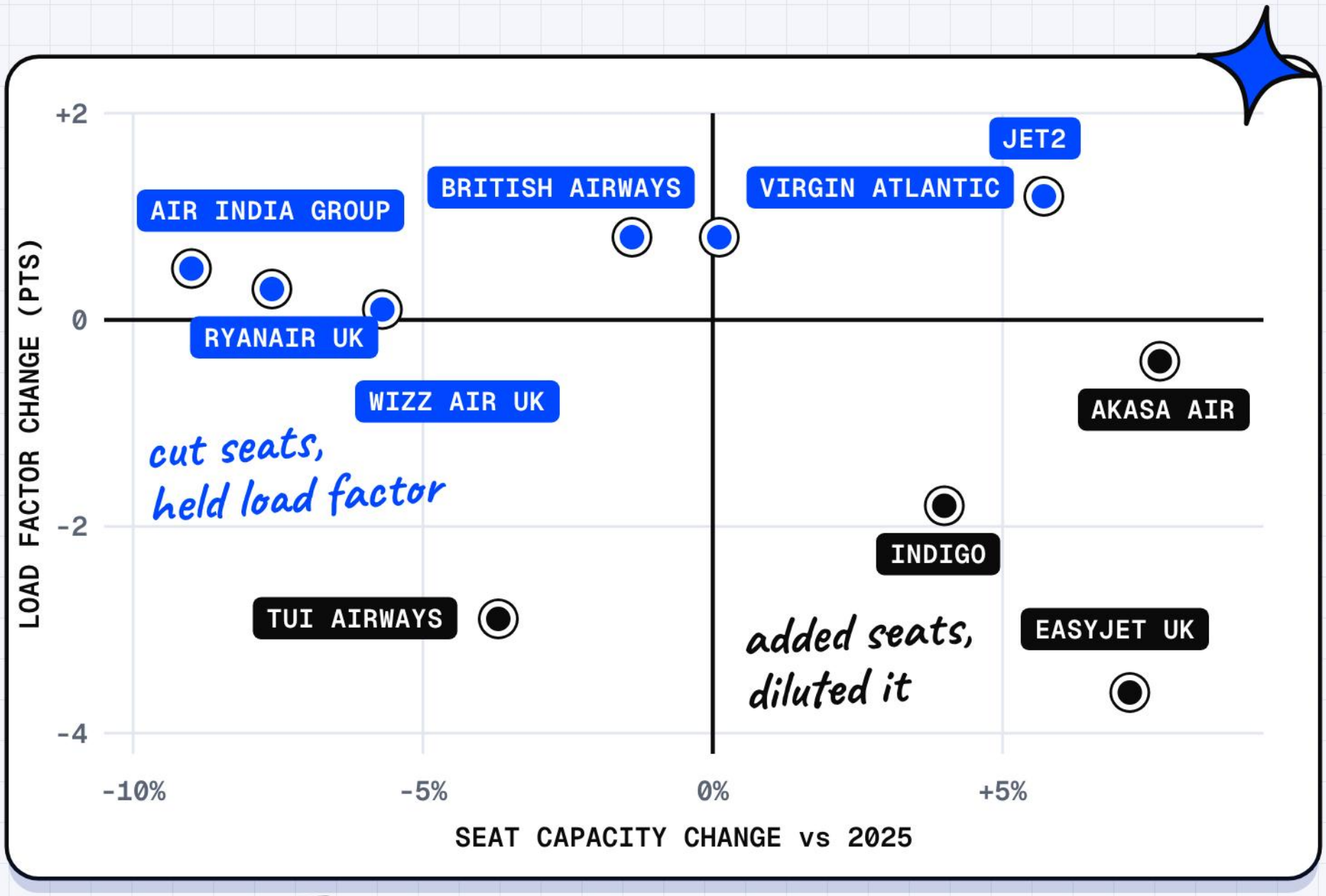
Air India Group -7.2% pax

easyJet UK -3.6 pts LF

I compared how 10 airlines handled the 2026 shock. Half cut capacity. Half added it. The results split hard.



Cutting seats **protected** load factor. **It cost passengers.**



Air India Group

-9.0%
SEATS

+0.5
LOAD FACTOR PTS

-7.2%
PASSENGERS

Not just a chart.
The work behind it.

sql/02_capacity_vs_load_factor.sql

```sql
WITH w AS (
    SELECT b.brand, d.year,
           SUM(f.ask_k) AS ask, SUM(f.rpk_k) AS rpk
    FROM fact_traffic f
    JOIN dim_brand b ON b.brand_id = f.brand_id
    JOIN dim_date  d ON d.month = f.month
    WHERE d.month_num BETWEEN 3 AND 8
      AND d.year IN (2025, 2026)
    GROUP BY b.brand, d.year
)
SELECT p25.brand,
       ROUND((p26.ask - p25.ask) * 100.0 / p25.ask, 1) AS capacity_chg_pct,
       ROUND(p25.rpk * 100.0 / p25.ask, 1) AS lf_2025,
       ROUND(p26.rpk * 100.0 / p26.ask, 1) AS lf_2026,
       ROUND(p26.rpk * 100.0 / p26.ask - p25.rpk * 100.0 / p25.ask, 1) AS lf_chg_pts
FROM w p25
JOIN w p26 ON p26.brand = p25.brand AND p26.year = 2026
WHERE p25.year = 2025
ORDER BY capacity_chg_pct;
```

notebooks/05_matched_windows.py

```python
keys = set(zip(f["brand_id"], f["month"]))
shift = lambda m, n: m + pd.DateOffset(years=n)

def window(r):
    m = r["month"]
    if pd.Timestamp("2026-03-01") <= m <= pd.Timestamp("2026-08-01") and (r["brand_id"], shift(m,
-1)) in keys:
        return "Shock"
    if pd.Timestamp("2025-03-01") <= m <= pd.Timestamp("2025-08-01") and (r["brand_id"], shift(m, 1))
in keys:
        return "Baseline"
    return "Other"

f["window"] = f.apply(window, axis=1)
```

Load factor is a **guardrail**, not the goal.

Cut only where volume is cheap to lose

Ryanair UK and Air India held load factor but lost 5 to 7% of passengers.

Add only where demand is proven

Jet2 grew seats 5.7% and filled them. easyJet UK added 7.2% and lost 3.6 pts.

THE HONEST BIT

Descriptive, not causal. No fare data, so no profit view. UK CAA and India DGCA define load factor slightly differently. SpiceJet left out (no 2025 data).

Built in Power BI, SQL, Python.

github.com/iguesshecodes/airline-shock-2026